Reflection Paper: Strategy in the Once-Only Technical System (OOTS)

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1 Introduction to the Organization

I work as an independent contractor for DIGIT-EU, the Directorate-General for Digital Services at the European Commission, on the Once-Only Technical System (OOTS) — a pan-European infrastructure that lets public authorities exchange documents securely across borders, so citizens and businesses do not have to submit the same information repeatedly [1].

OOTS retrieves data directly from the official source, with the user's explicit consent. It rests on four pillars: a **decentralized architecture** connecting existing national systems; **interoperability enablers** such as eID and eDelivery [2]; **user control and consent**; and **standardized evidence**, which matches procedural requirements in one country with equivalent data sources in another [3].

The organization is not a commercial enterprise and does not compete in a market. Its mission is to promote cooperation among sovereign nations and serve the public interest, which shapes how strategy is developed and executed.

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2 Strategic Statement and Reflection

OOTS has no formal strategic statement, but its documentation reveals a clear direction. Appendix C presents the statement I formulated from the available material. In short, the **mission** is to enable seamless, secure, consent-driven cross-border data exchange so that nobody provides the same information twice; the **vision** is a Union where digital interoperability is the norm and public services work as one system regardless of borders; and the **core values** are decentralization, trust and security, user empowerment, interoperability, reusability and cooperation.

2.1 Reflection

Unlike a commercial strategy built around market position and profit, this statement is about enabling cooperation and reducing friction. The values are telling. Decentralization is a political choice as much as a technical one, because Member States will not cede data sovereignty. Trust and security are prerequisites for handling sensitive data across borders. User empowerment reflects EU data protection values such as the GDPR, and reusability multiplies the value of each investment.

The statement could be stronger in two respects. First, it lacks measurable outcomes, such as the number of cross-border procedures supported or Member States connected by a given date. Second, it underplays reusability: the trusted connections, consent mechanisms and standardized evidence framework could serve other initiatives, such as the EU Digital Wallet, making OOTS a cornerstone of Authentic Public Sources across the EU digital ecosystem.

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3 Strategic Tools and Reflection

3.1 Current Practice

To my knowledge, OOTS does not formally apply classic tools such as Porter's Five Forces, SWOT or value chain analysis. This is unsurprising: they were designed for competitive markets, while OOTS cooperates with sovereign governments. Instead, it relies on three processes with a similar purpose:

- **Requests for Change (RFCs)**, which gather Member State feedback and build consensus.
- **Technical Design Documents (TDDs)**, which act as strategic and operational blueprints and record how the direction has evolved [4].
- **Open-source policy**, which publishes all code for transparency and community contribution [5].

Because none of the formal tools is used, I apply two myself: PESTEL to understand the external environment, and a stakeholder power/interest grid to decide who must be engaged.

3.2 Applying PESTEL Analysis

PESTEL examines the Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Environmental and Legal factors shaping an organisation. The full analysis is in Appendix A; the main findings are:

- **Political:** the main enabler and the main challenge. EU interoperability priorities drive funding, but securing buy-in from twenty-seven Member States with different governments and timelines requires sustained diplomacy.
- **Economic:** dependence on the EU budget and on Member States' capacity to invest, offset by clear benefits from lower compliance costs and faster administration.

- **Social:** citizens expect fast, borderless digital services, yet are concerned about privacy, so transparency and consent are essential.
- **Technological:** the decentralized architecture is complex, and cybersecurity is a constant concern.
- **Environmental:** less printing, postage and travel, plus the Green Digital Agenda's push for energy-efficient infrastructure.
- **Legal:** the most complex factor, spanning the GDPR, eIDAS, the Once-Only Regulation and national laws; each exchange must satisfy both Member States involved.

Political and legal factors dominate, followed by technological and social ones; economic and environmental factors play a secondary role. The factors are also interdependent: a political decision to strengthen data protection creates new legal requirements, which demand technological solutions that citizens must accept. A strategist must navigate these links continuously.

3.3 Applying Stakeholder Analysis (Power/Interest Grid)

PESTEL describes the environment but not the actors. I therefore complement it with Mendelow's power/interest grid, which classifies stakeholders by their power over the project and their interest in it (Appendix B):

- **Manage closely (high power, high interest):** the European Commission, Member State governments and national authorities. They decide whether the system is adopted, so they are engaged through RFCs and steering groups.
- **Keep satisfied (high power, low interest):** the European Parliament and Council, data protection authorities and finance ministries. They need updates on compliance and value for money.
- **Keep informed (low power, high interest):** citizens, businesses, the open-source community, implementers and other EU initiatives. They are served through public repositories, documentation and feedback channels.
- **Monitor (low power, low interest):** the general public and non-participating third countries.

The grid confirms that the key stakeholders are public bodies, not customers or competitors. The RFC process serves the high-power, high-interest group well but is less effective for the others: data protection authorities and citizens are not systematically engaged, although they strongly influence legitimacy and trust. Positions also shift: as other EU initiatives reuse OOTS, they gain interest and power. The tools are complementary: PESTEL shows which external forces matter, and the grid shows who must be engaged to respond to them.

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4 Verdict: How Strategy Is Developed and Executed, and Ways to Improve

4.1 Assessment

Strategy in OOTS is collaborative, iterative and documentation-driven. RFCs ensure broad participation, TDDs guide implementation, and the open-source policy supports transparency. This suits the project's cooperative, non-commercial nature.

However, without formal strategic analysis the direction is largely implicit. Decisions are made reactively, in response to technical challenges, political pressure or legal change, rather than guided by a structured framework. RFCs and TDDs are excellent for technical governance but do not replace periodic strategic review.

4.2 Recommendations for Improvement

1. **Adopt PESTEL and the stakeholder grid as periodic review tools,** for example at the start of each major release cycle, to anticipate external challenges and keep engagement up to date. This would formalise the stakeholder map that the RFC process currently covers only for Member States.
2. **Develop measurable strategic objectives,** such as "Support fifty cross-border procedures by 2027" or "Achieve full Member State connectivity by 2028," to make progress tangible.
3. **Engage under-served stakeholders,** notably data protection authorities and citizens, through structured consultation.
4. **Establish a lessons-learned repository** to capture the lessons of each iteration and avoid repeating mistakes.
5. **Consider an adapted balanced scorecard** tracking technical delivery, stakeholder satisfaction, legal compliance and user impact.
6. **Articulate reusability as a strategic asset,** positioning OOTS as the gateway to Authentic Public Sources for initiatives such as the EU Digital Wallet, to attract broader support.

4.3 Conclusion

OOTS is an ambitious effort to make the digital single market real. Its strategy is shaped by cooperation rather than competition and by the interplay of politics, law and technology across twenty-seven sovereign nations. Its current processes fit this context, but the deliberate use of tools such as PESTEL and stakeholder analysis would help it anticipate challenges, measure progress and communicate its direction. The goal is not to impose commercial frameworks on a public mission, but to borrow whatever tools are useful and adapt them to its purpose.

References

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[5] European Commission. *OOTS Common Services*. Retrieved from https://code.europa.eu/oots/common-services

[6] European Commission. *Two systems, one vision*. Retrieved from https://ec.europa.eu/digital-building-blocks/sites/spaces/OOTS/pages/930450665/Two+systems+one+vision

A PESTEL Analysis

Factor	Key Influences on OOTS
Political	EU digital interoperability priorities (European Interoperability Framework, Once-Only Regulation); Commission funding and coordination; buy-in from all twenty-seven Member States; geopolitical tensions; changes in national governments and EU leadership
Economic	Funding through the EU budget and fiscal cycles; Member State capacity to invest in national connections; lower compliance costs, faster administrative processing and improved cross-border trade
Social	Citizen expectations for convenient, borderless digital services; increasing mobility within the EU; concerns about data privacy and surveillance
Technological	Decentralised architecture complexity (data mapping, format translation, real-time validation); open-source model (innovation versus quality assurance and coordination); cybersecurity threats
Environmental	Reduced printing, postal services and in-person visits; Green Digital Agenda and energy-efficient data centres
Legal	GDPR; eIDAS Regulation; Once-Only Regulation; national data protection laws; international data transfer agreements; legislative changes at EU or national level

Table 1: PESTEL Analysis for OOTS

B Stakeholder Analysis (Power/Interest Grid)

	Low interest	**High interest**
High power	**Keep satisfied:** European Parliament and Council; national data protection authorities; Member State finance ministries	**Manage closely:** European Commission (DIGIT); Member State governments and national coordinators; national competent authorities (data providers)
Low power	**Monitor:** general public; non-participating third countries	**Keep informed:** citizens and businesses; open-source community; service providers and implementers; other EU initiatives (e.g., the EU Digital Wallet)

Table 2: Stakeholder Power/Interest Grid for OOTS

C Strategic Statement

Mission: To enable seamless, secure, and consent-driven cross-border data exchange across the European Union, so that citizens and businesses never have to provide the same information to public authorities more than once.

Vision: A European Union in which digital interoperability between Member States is the norm, bureaucratic barriers are eliminated, and public services work as one cohesive system regardless of national borders.

Core Values:

- **Decentralization.** Respect for national data sovereignty while enabling connectivity.
- **Trust and Security.** Every exchange is encrypted, authenticated, and auditable.
- **User Empowerment.** Citizens and businesses retain full control over their data.
- **Interoperability.** Seamless connectivity between diverse national systems, technologies, and legal frameworks without requiring harmonisation.
- **Reusability.** Infrastructure that serves multiple EU initiatives beyond its original scope.
- **Cooperation.** Collaboration among Member States rather than competition.

D AI Usage Notice

This reflection paper was drafted with the assistance of an AI writing assistant (Junie, by JetBrains - Junie Lite Model). The author provided all source material, project context and reviewed the final output. AI assistant organized the ideas and provided a clearer structure to the reflection paper. The author takes full responsibility for the content and academic integrity of this work.